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SUPER SYNERGY Shekhawat (centre) with Sharma (left) and Yadav at the MoU signing for the PKC-ERCP Link Project, Jan. 28

RAJASTHAN

Double-engine Juggernaut

By Rohit Parihar

The newly elected Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in Rajasthan may look inexperienced—given that 20 of its 24 ministers, including Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma, are in office for the first time—but having a 'double-engine' government in place comes as a boon. In the first display of this Centre-state synergy, Union jal shakti minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat brought Rajasthan and neighbouring Madhya Pradesh across the table soon after the formation of new BJP governments in both states to move forward on the Eastern Rajasthan Canal Project (ERCP), which has been stuck in political wrangling for years.

On January 28, Sharma met his MP counterpart Mohan Lal Yadav in Jaipur to iron out any last-minute kinks before the two proceeded to New Delhi to sign a memorandum of understanding (MoU) to roll out the Modified Parvati-Kalisindh-Chambal (PKC)-ERCP Link Project. Now part of the ambitious National River Linking Project, it proposes to utilise the surplus rainwater in the Chambal basin to provide drinking and industrial water to 13 districts of eastern Rajasthan and parts of MP, apart from irrigating 280,000 hectares each of agricultural land in both states.

Proposed during the previous BJP regime led by Vasundhara Raje, the ERCP failed to take off due to the MP government's objections. The Ashok Gehlot-led Congress regime in Rajasthan tried to make it an election issue even as Shekhawat had started looking for alternative options on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's advice. Though the project will still take time to see the light of day, the signing of the MoU indicates that the Centre's support will keep the fledgling Sharma regime on the right track. Modi's Republic Day-eve roadshow with French president Emmanuel Macron in Jaipur—where both could be seen enjoying *kulhad chai*—only reaffirms that the PM wants to keep the spotlight on the desert state.

The Eastern River Canal is now part of a more ambitious river-linking project between Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh

The new CM, on his part, is spending significant time in meetings, travelling and engaging with the public in an attempt to understand issues at the ground level. He even surprised many by personally inspecting a police station and a homeless shelter in Jaipur late one night. "Of course, I keep running behind schedule," says Sharma. "So, I have cut down on the time spent on personal chores." The CM showed that he means business when, on January 23, chief secretary Sudhansh Pant made a surprise visit to the Jaipur Development Authority (JDA), among the agencies accused of rampant corruption, and found many files held up for no valid reason. Within hours, JDA secretary Nalini Kathotia and two other officers were shunted out.

With bureaucratic reshuffles still limited, the continuity of officials from the previous regime raises apprehensions even as investigations have been ordered into "whimsical" projects undertaken by the Gehlot regime, such as the ongoing construction of a 24-storey inpatient department tower at the highly congested Sawai Man Singh Hospital in Jaipur, the elevated road project in Ajmer and the Kota Riverfront development. Sharma will have to ensure these inquiries reach their logical conclusion in order to break the nexus between middlemen and corrupt officials. The true test will come in the upcoming parliamentary election, where the BJP seeks a third straight clean sweep in Rajasthan. ■